

THE OBJECT IN THE LOCKER: FABLE'S TEN ·

2026-09-08

Fresh Fable agent, no tools, given exactly the text below the line of prompt-gpt-four-keys-locker-object-2026-09-08.md. Filed verbatim. GPT's result goes beside it; a disposition follows; Stephen rules. Nothing here is approved.

A note before the list, because it is load-bearing for every candidate: Brad has read her true letter. Whatever oddity the forged letter attaches to the object can be one she actually noticed and wrote down, so he never has to invent a symptom, only choose which of her real ones to pin to which object.

1. Her mother's mantel clock, a brass-faced eight-day striker that stood on Violet's front-room mantel and that all four have heard chime through every dinner she ever gave. The letter: "Mum's clock is in the locker. I let it run down after the funeral and left it stopped, and on the ninth it was going. I don't wind that clock. I'm not keeping a thing in the house that somebody else is keeping time on." Brad lifts it off the mantel on his way out; a pale rectangle on the wallpaper tells the police it stood there for years and tells nobody when it left, and the letter has already said she moved it. By the third meeting the room has worked out that only one of them ever knew the woman whose clock it was, that he is the sort of man who cannot walk past a stopped clock, and that he has said, at that table, "I couldn't have looked at it stopped either," which the others hear as the confession of a man who wound it. Margo sees the hands, stopped at ten past three. She knows Violet's habits from the books and the confidence, knows the letter's date, and does the arithmetic on an eight-day movement wound full and locked on that date: it would have run down on the night Violet died, in a padlocked locker a mile from the stairs, at about the hour the coroner gave. The message to Tessa is that arithmetic. The clock in her cupboard has stopped at the hour her friend fell and Margo cannot make herself believe it is chance, and cannot let herself believe it is anything else. The survivors will not name it because to name it is to admit they tried a man on whether he had wound a dead woman's clock, and because one of them has the clock now and has never wound it again. The one thing that fails it is the image itself: a clock that starts on its own is a ghost story, and the first time anyone at the table says the word ghost the fear goes soft and stays soft.

2. Her mother's ashes, in the plain grey scatter-tube the crematorium supplies, which the four know because it stood on the shelf in the back bedroom through the wake and Violet said, once, that she would take her mother out to the point when she could face it. The letter: "Mum is in the locker. She was on the shelf facing the window and on the ninth she was facing the door. I do not turn her. I am not leaving her in a house I can't say is empty." Brad carries out something the size of a biscuit tin; nobody but Violet knew the shelf, the police photograph a shelf with a book on it, and an absence nobody can place cannot be dated. By the third meeting the room has recalled that Liam asked twice this year to take the ashes out on his boat, that Violet said no both times, and that a man who wanted that badly to move her mother might go and stand with her when the house was empty. Margo alone knows the mother's house and the name it was sold under, because Violet told her where the money came from. The crematorium label carries a different surname. It is the maiden name, which Violet never mentioned and never needed to, but Margo expected the name she knows and it is not there. The message to Tessa is that label: the thing in the cupboard is under the wrong name, and Margo will not let it mean that the story of the money, or the woman in the tube, was not what she was told. The survivors will not name it because there is no way to tell a podcaster that they kept their friend's mother in a kitchen cupboard for three weeks and read her position on a shelf like tea leaves, and because the question of where she is now

would follow and they will not answer it. The one thing that fails it is tone: played a shade too hard it is gothic, and it obliges the writers to know, and eventually say, what became of the ashes.

3. The Boxing Day brandy, a square cut-glass decanter the four have drunk from every year at Violet's, with a pencil line and a date down the side of the label in her hand for every year since she first hosted. The letter: "The brandy is in the locker because on the ninth it was two fingers under the Christmas line and I have not touched it. I'm not leaving it out to be drunk by somebody I can't see." Brad takes a decanter off a sideboard; a sideboard with one decanter on it is the least remarkable photograph the police take, and nobody counts another woman's drink. By the third meeting the room knows that Ruby is on nights and does not drink, that Margo has a glass a year, and that Liam drinks brandy and has known where Violet keeps it for thirty years; nobody says it, and everybody has said it. Margo alone knows that Violet stopped drinking entirely on the night she signed her mother's house away, because Violet told her so in the same breath as the money, so while the other two half-believe Violet drank it herself in a bad week and imagined the rest, Margo knows the level cannot be Violet's. Then the decanter, kept in Margo's kitchen cupboard between meetings with the level marked and initialled by all three, is lower again. The message to Tessa is exactly that: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, and it cannot mean that somebody is coming into Margo's house too. The survivors will not name it because they measured a bottle like detectives and counted a dead friend's drinking against her, and because they finished it together after the second funeral and will not say so. The one thing that fails it is that a dropping level is a cliché, and a loose stopper in a warm cupboard is the first thing a nurse would say; if Ruby says it at meeting two, the object is dead.

4. Her mother's one record, a 78 in a brown paper sleeve with the mother's name pencilled on it, which the four know because Violet played it once at the wake and took it off before it finished. The letter: "Mum's record is in the locker. On the ninth it was on the turntable with the arm across it. I have not played it since the wake and I haven't the stomach to keep it where it can be played." Brad slides a record into his coat; a shelf of records is a shelf of records in a police photograph and no one alive but Violet knew its place. By the third meeting the room has remembered who was dancing with Violet's mother at Violet's twenty-first, who owns a turntable that plays 78s, and who said "she used to play that on Sundays" without being asked, which is the sound of a man who knew what the record was for. Margo sees the small price sticker on the back of the sleeve from a second-hand shop, dated this spring. She knows the mother's things went in the house clearance because the clearance sat inside the sale figures Violet told her about, and she alone understands that Violet was quietly buying her mother's things back, with the money, one at a time, telling no one. The message to Tessa is that sticker: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, and Margo will not let it mean that the woman who said she wanted none of that house was going back for it piece by piece. The survivors will not name it because naming the record means the podcast plays it, and they will not have that song played. The one thing that fails it is that it needs a real song, a song the reader can hear, and if the song is wrong or unclearable the object is wrong.

5. The school teapot, brown and lopsided, her name scratched under the base, spout snapped since 2019 and kept on the dresser anyway because she made tea in it for anyone who came, which is all four. The letter: "The teapot is in the locker because on the ninth it had a spout again. I did not glue it. Somebody in my house glued my teapot, so it isn't staying in my house." Brad takes a teapot off a dresser full of crockery; the police photograph a dresser. By the third meeting someone has turned the spout to the light and named the glue, grey two-part marine epoxy, and there is exactly one boatyard man at the table. Margo sees that the glue is yellowed and there is dust in the join: the mend is years old, not weeks. She did Violet's books through the winter after the mother died and saw the state of her, and reads it as Violet mending it herself that winter and forgetting she had, and then everything else in the letter tilts toward a woman who was losing her grip, and

the stairs become what happens to such a woman. The message to Tessa is that: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, the mend is old, and it cannot mean that Violet was imagining all of it and simply fell. The survivors will not name it because a glued teapot makes them ridiculous and makes her ridiculous, and grief refuses bathos. The one thing that fails it is the same bathos: a teapot cannot carry a padlocked locker unless the fragility and the glue are played dead straight, and epoxy points at Liam so hard the letter hardly needs to.

6. Her mother's walking stick, the hospice-issue one with the grey rubber foot and the hospital tape still round the shaft, which stood in the hall stand by Violet's door where all four have hung a coat on it. The letter: "Mum's stick is in the locker. It stood in the hall since she died. On the ninth it was at the top of the stairs, hooked on the newel post. I don't take it upstairs. I'm not keeping a thing in the house that somebody else is moving about." Brad takes it from the hall stand on his way out; an umbrella stand with umbrellas in it is not evidence of anything, and no one can say when the stick left it. By the third meeting the room has agreed that only one of them ever saw the mother walk with it, only one knows what the tape was for because he drove her to the hospice, and only he would know to put it where she used to need it. Margo sees the rubber foot, worn to a fresh slant on one side, the wear of a living user. She knows from the physio invoices she paid in January that Violet hurt her ankle and told no one, and understands that Violet was using her mother's stick on the stairs herself. The message to Tessa is the foot: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, the wear is new, and it cannot mean that Violet was unsteady on those stairs and nobody moved anything. The survivors will not name it because a stick at the top of the stairs says murder on a podcast, and they have chosen to believe the coroner because the alternative is each other. The one thing that fails it is that it aims at the stairs too well: it drags the death from accident toward murder and the room toward the police, against the letter's own instruction.

7. The slate house sign from her mother's front door, the house name cut and gilded by Violet at sixteen, her first paid job, which she unscrewed the day she handed over the keys and kept on the kitchen windowsill, where all four have seen it. The letter: "The slate is in the locker because on the ninth it was face to the wall and I don't turn it. It is the only thing of that house I kept and I won't have it where somebody else can handle it." Brad takes a slate off a windowsill; a windowsill is a windowsill. By the third meeting the room has worked out that only one of them ever saw that house with the slate on its door, and that he asked Violet for the slate twice, which is on the starter list because it is true. Margo alone knows which house the money came from, because Violet named it the night she told her. The name on the slate is not that house. The answer is innocent, the grandmother's house that the mother inherited and renamed, but Margo does not have the answer, only the wrong name. The message to Tessa is the name: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, and it cannot mean there was another house, or another source. The survivors will not name it because naming the slate names the house, and the house is the money, and the money was Violet's private business that Margo kept for her and that they now keep. The one thing that fails it is that it drags the money to the table, which the story wants kept out of the room, and it is a lettered board from her hall, one step from the object that was just rejected.

8. Her mother's carving knife, bone handle, ten-inch blade, the one that comes out every Christmas at Violet's and is sharpened at the table before the bird. The letter: "The knife is in the locker because on the ninth it was on the bathroom windowsill and I don't take knives upstairs. I'm not keeping it in the house." Brad takes it from the block; a knife block with one slot empty is a knife block. By the third meeting the room has noticed that the edge is fresh, that Violet could not sharpen a knife to save her life, and that one man at the table has sharpened it every Christmas for a decade. Margo knows Violet told her, the night of the money, that she had kept nothing from her mother's kitchen, "nothing sharp from that house," and here the knife is, so either Violet kept it and lied or somebody carried it into the house. The message to Tessa is that: the thing in the

cupboard is wrong, and it cannot mean that Violet lied to her, or that a knife came in through the door with whoever came in. The survivors will not name it because they will not give the town a knife. The one thing that fails it is that a knife makes it a thriller: a blade in a padlocked locker asks for police in a way no letter can talk the room out of.

9. The biscuit tin of her mother's end-of-life medicines, oral morphine and a strip of ampoules that should have gone back to the pharmacy and never did, which lived on top of Violet's wardrobe and which all four saw in the last week, Ruby with a professional eye. The letter: "Mum's tin is in the locker because on the ninth there were nine ampoules and I know it was eleven. I should have handed it in. I'm not handing it to whoever is in my house." Brad takes the tin; nobody photographs the top of a wardrobe and nobody but Violet counted. By the third meeting the room has noted that Liam has had the crane driver's back all year and has been off the beer since March, which is on the starter list because it is true, and the room reads one thing swapped for another. Margo sees that the pharmacy labels are dated after the mother's death, and knows from a private clinic line in the accounts that Violet queried away, that the medicine was not the mother's at all. The message to Tessa is the dates: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, and it cannot mean that Violet was ill and told none of them. The survivors will not name it because naming it says on a podcast that Violet was on her mother's morphine, and they will not do that to her, and because possession is an offence they all committed by keeping it. The one thing that fails it is that a nurse at the table is the natural suspect for missing morphine, so the arrow swings to Ruby, not Liam, and it adds "Violet was ill" to canon whether the writers want it or not.

10. Her gold, a flat tin of loose 23-carat leaf in a dozen books, kept for the good jobs and worth more than her van, which the four know because she has shown each of them a book of it lifted on a gilder's tip as a party piece. The letter: "The gold is in the locker because on the ninth there were eleven books and I count them. I'm not leaving it in a house with an open door." Brad takes a tin from a kitchen drawer; the police do not photograph the inside of drawers. By the third meeting the room has moved from who would steal to who needs money, and Liam sold his car in March, which is on the starter list because it is true. Margo, who reconciles Violet's supplier invoices, sees more gold in the tin than the books ever bought, and understands that Violet was spending her mother's money in cash on stock the accounts never saw. The message to Tessa is the count: the thing in the cupboard is wrong, and it cannot mean that Violet was hiding money from her own accountant. The survivors will not name it because gold on a podcast makes Violet a woman robbed for gold, and because of what one of them said about the other's money at the table. The one thing that fails it is that gold leaf points straight at the other signwriter in the room, and an object that needs the table to clear Brad out loud is the wrong object.

Ranking.

1. The ashes, because it is the only candidate where the locker is not merely natural but the only decent place, and the only one where the survivors' silence needs no explaining at all.
2. The clock, because it does everything the ashes do at a lower temperature, and loses only because the stopped-hands beat is a coincidence the writers must engineer rather than a fact the world gives them.
3. The brandy, because its cupboard beat is the truest fit for Margo's exact words, and it beats the record only because it needs no song.
4. The record, because Margo's reading of it, a woman buying her mother back one piece at a time, is the best private discovery in the set, and it beats the teapot because a record on a turntable is uncanny where a teapot is not.
5. The teapot, because its "she was imagining it" turn is the most on-theme Margo beat here, and it beats the stick because it does not send the room to the police.

6. The stick, because it makes the fear more physical than anything below it and beats the slate because it keeps the money out of the room.
7. The slate, because it is a clean intrusion object with a real Liam pull and beats the knife because it is not a weapon.
8. The knife, because it at least keeps Liam as the arrow, which the morphine does not.
9. The morphine, because its Margo beat is strong and its arrow is wrong, and it still beats the gold because nothing in it looks at Brad.
10. The gold, because it is the one object in the room that a second signwriter would want.